

You cannot price your way out of a distribution problem.

One inference from 1,000 payment-verified startups, and what it means for where you spend the next twelve months.

1,000 startups that let their revenue be verified

1,000

Companies

Stripe, RevenueCat, Paddle,
Polar, Superwall and 5 more

\$13.5m

Total monthly revenue

\$161.7m implied ARR
\$334m all-time

500,597

Active subscriptions

Median company: 16
Median MRR: \$282

0.90

Gini on MRR

9% of companies produce
80% of the revenue

Read this before anything else

Not a random sample. Three filters are baked in: founders opt in, only modern subscription rails are covered, and dead companies never appear. Failure is understated; enterprise and invoice-billed businesses are absent entirely. Everything that follows describes **internet-native, subscription-billed, mostly solo-founder software** — and nothing wider.

Revenue in this market is a volume problem wearing a pricing problem's clothes.

$$\text{MRR} = \text{subscribers} \times \$20$$

Median ARPU is \$19.50 and it does not move. Across a 650× range of company size, from \$29 MRR to \$18,854 MRR, the typical customer pays the same twenty dollars a month. The entire variance in outcome is explained by how many customers a company reaches — not by what it charges them.

Scale 650× and the price per customer doesn't budge

Median ARPU by subscriber quartile



Median MRR of the same four groups

Q1	\$29
Q2	\$378
Q3	\$2,120
Q4	\$18,854

Spearman correlation between ARPU and subscriber count: 0.013
($p = 0.71$). Statistically, no relationship at all.

One variable explains almost three-quarters of the outcome

0.98

Elasticity of MRR to subscriber count

Indistinguishable from 1.0. Double the customers, double the revenue — no more, no less.

0.72

R^2 from subscriber count alone

n = 789 revenue-positive companies

+1.3%

R^2 added by followers, SEO and everything else

X followers: not significant (t = 0.43)

■ **So what.** Every hour spent on pricing architecture — tiers, packaging, value metrics — is being spent on the flat part of the curve. The slope lives entirely in customer count.

The popular monetisation levers correlate the wrong way

4.7×

LOWER

Free tier

Companies advertising a free tier post a median MRR of \$159 against \$751 for those that don't.

$p < 0.001$ · $n = 657$

3.5×

LOWER

Lifetime / one-time pricing

Median MRR of \$124 against \$434. Cash today, but a hard ceiling on the recurring base.

$p < 0.001$ · $n = 85$

0.0

EFFECT

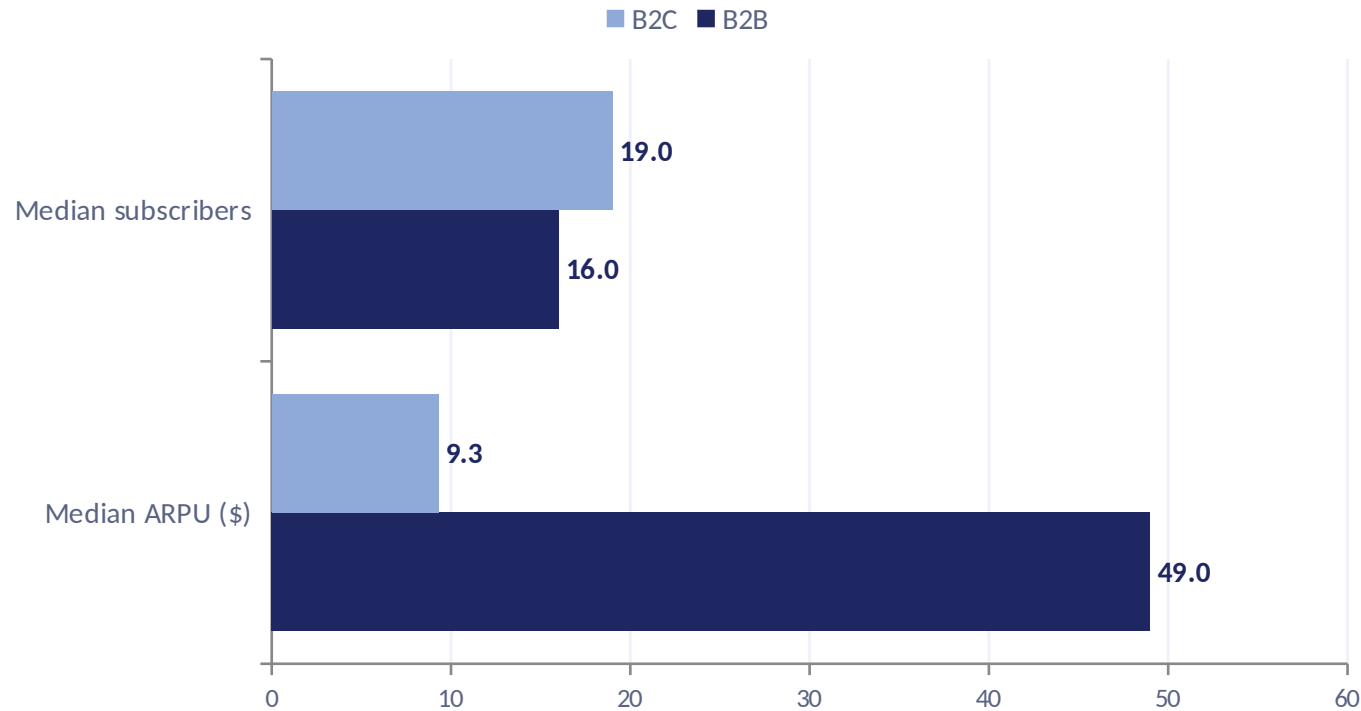
X audience size

Once subscriber count is controlled for, follower count adds nothing. Below 1,000 followers, no signal at all.

$t = 0.43$ · not significant

Correlation, not causation — free tiers may be a symptom of weak distribution rather than a cause of weak revenue. Either reading points the same way: the pricing page is not where the outcome is decided.

B2B wins on price alone — same customer count, 5× the revenue



Mann-Whitney on ARPU, B2B vs B2C: $p = 5.8e-44$ — the strongest single effect in the dataset. $n = 656$.

5.7×

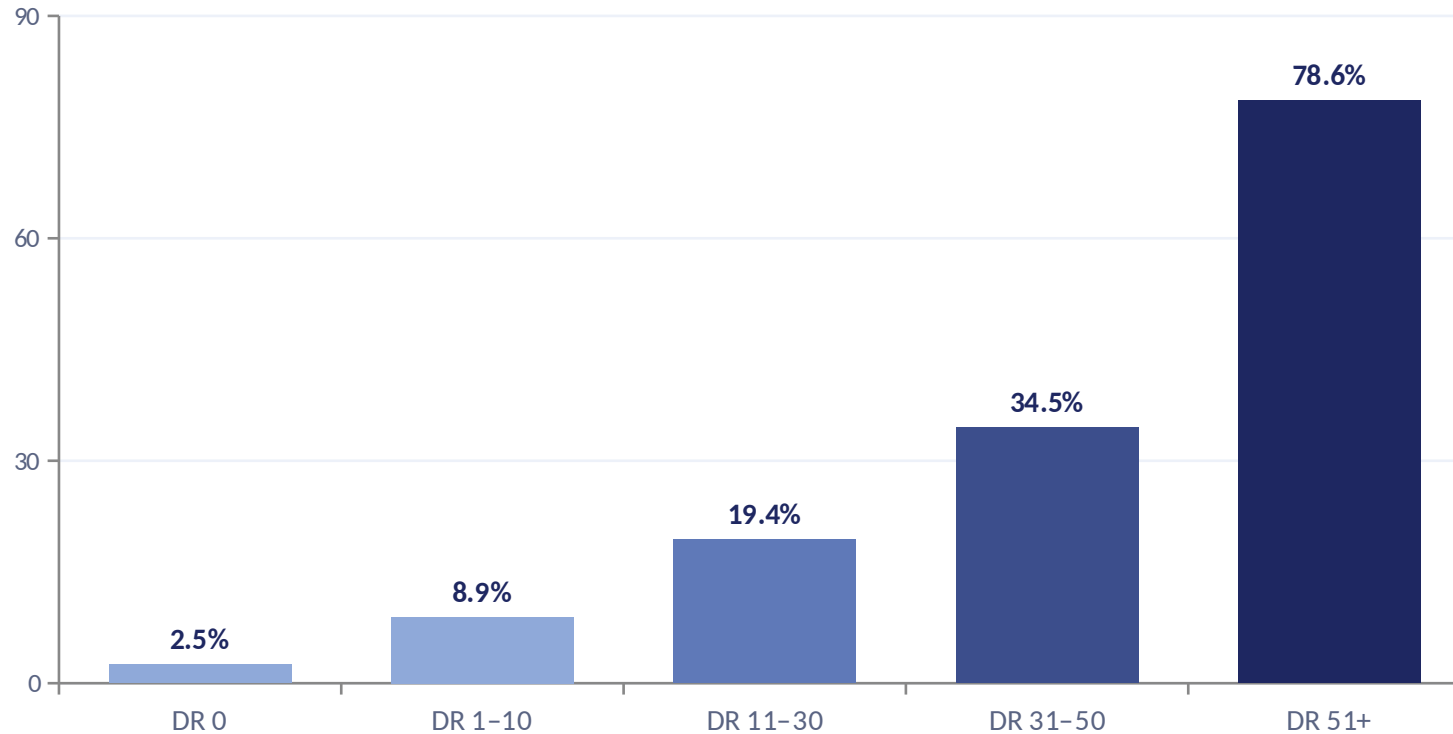
Median MRR: \$1,036 for B2B against \$181 for B2C, on near-identical subscriber counts.

Why this is the exception that proves the rule

B2B does not reach more people. It reaches the same number of people who can pay five times as much. That is the only pricing lever in the dataset that clears significance — and it is a customer-selection decision, not a pricing-page decision.

Owned distribution moves the odds by 30 percentage points

Probability of crossing \$10,000 MRR, by domain authority band



31×

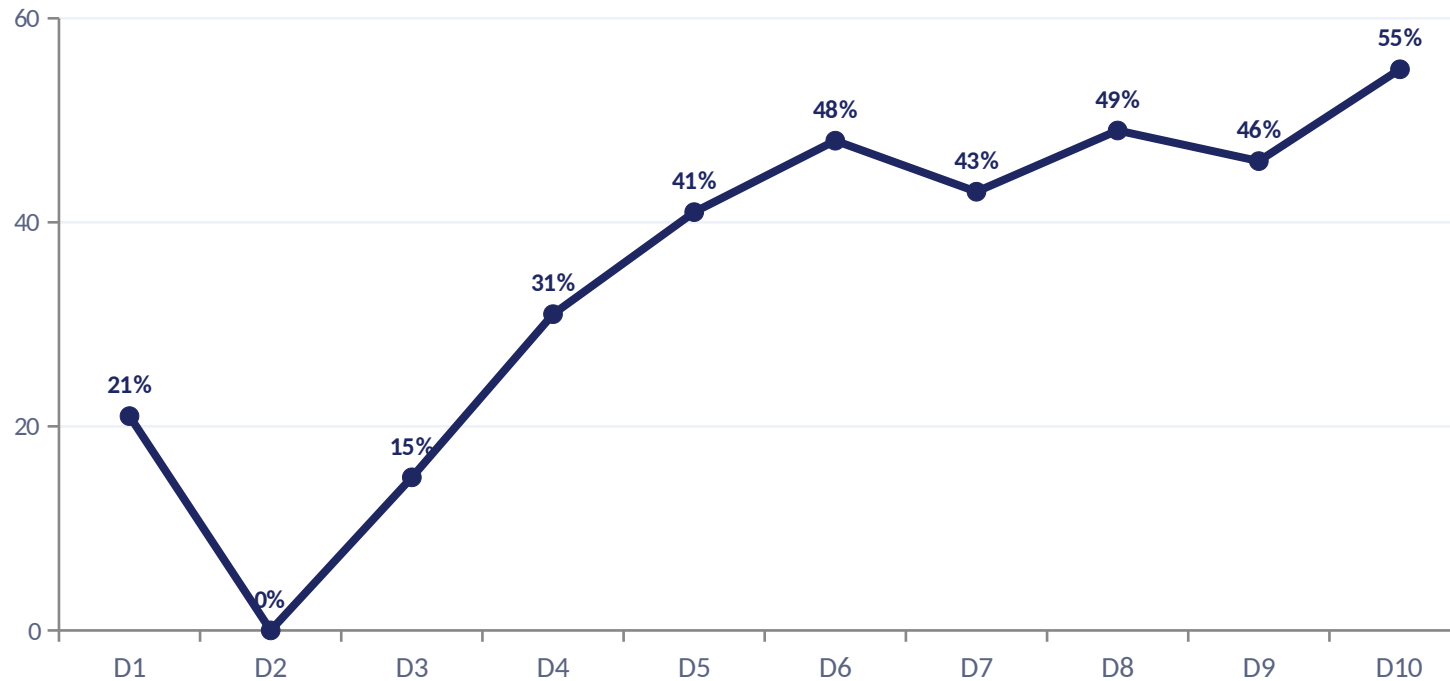
Better odds at DR 51+ than at DR 0. Base rate across all 1,000 companies is 21.2%.

Read it honestly

Causality runs both ways — authority builds revenue, and revenue attracts links. The data is a single frozen snapshot and cannot separate them. What it does support: domain authority is the best screening variable available, with Spearman $\rho = 0.49$ against MRR.

Being small does not make you agile — it makes you stuck

Share of companies growing month-on-month, by MRR decile (D1 = smallest)



0.0%

Median monthly revenue growth across all 1,000 companies. Flat is the single most common outcome.

0.90 → 0.94

Gini on revenue rises from the monthly window to the all-time window. Advantage accumulates.

3.0%

Of companies lost 100% of revenue in the last 30 days. At any snapshot, roughly 1 in 33 is dying.

The mean growth rate of 42% is an artefact: a company moving from \$10 to \$800 registers as +7,900%. The 5%-trimmed mean is 3.1%.

Three decisions this inference should change

01

Choose who pays before you choose what to charge

The customer-type decision is worth 5.7× on median revenue. Pricing-page work is worth roughly nothing. Re-sequence: pick the buyer, then set the number.

Owner: founder / product

02

Fund the distribution asset, not the pricing experiment

Domain authority above 30 doubles the odds of reaching \$10k MRR and above 50 quadruples them. Treat SEO, partnerships and channel as the capital expenditure they are.

Owner: growth / marketing

03

Underwrite acquisitions on raw revenue, never on the stated multiple

26% of these companies are for sale at a median ask of \$35,000. The dataset's own revenue_multiple field reconciles to nothing — correlation of -0.01 with asking price over revenue.

Owner: corp dev / investors

What this dataset cannot tell you

■ No cost data anywhere

MRR is gross. No COGS, no ad spend, no founder salary. Nothing here speaks to profitability — which is what actually decides survival and value.

■ One frozen snapshot

Cross-sectional, 30 July 2026. Every growth figure rests on a single 30-day window. No causal claim is supportable from this file.

■ Two broken fields

revenue_multiple reconciles to no raw column ($r = -0.01$), and 59 rows carry impossible revenue-window values. Recompute or discard both.

■ Means are meaningless here

Tail index $\alpha \approx 1.1$, so the population mean does not converge. Bootstrap CI for the mean spans \$8.2k–\$22.1k; for the median it is a tight \$208–\$440.

One company — Stan — is 26.5% of all MRR in the file. Any total, average or Pearson correlation quoted from this dataset is largely a statement about that single row.

THE ONE LINE

Nobody in this market is winning because they charged more.

They are winning because more people found them. Spend accordingly.

Source: TrustMRR 1,000-row dataset, frozen 30 July 2026. Analysis of 29 variables across 1,000 payment-verified startups.